Analyzing Literature

EDP 612

Week 6

Reference Text

Please download

Machi, L.A., & McEvoy, B.T. (2021). The Literature Review: Six Steps to Success (4th ed.). SAGE Publications.

Part I: Basic Overview

Guideline 1

- Scan the articles to get an overview of each one
  - Read the first few paragraphs
  - Read the entire Methods section
  - Scan rest of article

Guideline 2

- Based on your overview, group the articles by category
  - By topics and then subtopics
  - By chronological order within subtopic

Guideline 3

- Organize yourself before reading the articles
  - Computer
  - Pack of note cards to write your comments on
  - Self-adhesive flags that you can use to identify noteworthy comments (or word processing program to highlight)

Guideline 4

- Use a consistent format in your notes
  - Example
    - Author(s)' Last Name(s), Initial(s)
    - Title of Article
    - Publication Year
    - Name of Journal, Volume, Edition, Page Numbers
    - Notes

Guideline 5

- Look for explicit definitions of key terms in the literature

Guideline 6

- Look for methodological strengths

Guideline 7

- Look for methodological weaknesses

Guideline 8

- Distinguish between assertion and evidence
  - Assertion = author’s opinion
  - Evidence = results of study

Guideline 9

- Identify the major trends or patterns in the results of previous studies
- Generalization based on sources included in literature review

Guideline 10

- Identify gaps in the literature

Guideline 11

- Identify relationships among studies

Guideline 12

- Note how each reviewed article relates to your topic

Guideline 13

- Evaluate your reference list for relevancy and coverage
  - Should demonstrate latest work done in subject area

Part II: Analyzing Literature from the Viewpoint of a Researcher

Guideline 1

- State whether the study is quantitative or qualitative
  - Research is neither quantitative or qualitative
  - So please do not say *the research was...*

Guideline 2

- Determine whether a study is experimental or nonexperimental
  - *Experimental*. Treatments are administered to participants for the purposes of the study and their effects are assessed
  - *Nonexperimental*. Participants' traits are measured without attempting to change them

Guideline 3

- In an experiment, note whether the participants were assigned at random to treatment conditions
    - *True experiment*. Participants randomly assigned to treatment and control groups

Guideline 4

- Note attempts to examine cause-and-effect issues in nonexperimental studies
  - *Causal-comparative*. Uncover relationships between independent and dependent variables after an action or event has already occurred

    > aka *retroactive*
    >
    > aka *ex post facto*

Guideline 5

- Note how the major variables were measured
  - *Valid*. Measure what they claim to measure
  - *Reliable*. Yield consistent results

Guideline 6

- Note the characteristics of the samples of participants, such as
  - Demographics
  - Geographic location
  - Gender
  - Race
  - Ethnicity
  - Age
  - SES

Guideline 7

- Note how large a difference is – not just whether it is statistically significant
- So don't just report the p-value which by itself is nonsense

Guideline 8

- It is safe to presume that all empirical studies are flawed
- Never ever ever ever use the word "prove" when discussing results

Guideline 9

- Make note of the limitations within each study

These **are not** limits placed on your own study due to another study!

These **are** constraints placed on the ability to generalize from the results

- Given enough of a pattern, this provides you with justification to conduct a study of your own without infringing on another
  - Found by summarizing and synthesizing
  - Ultimate purpose of the literaure review!

That’s it!

Any questions?